Further, Akbar allowed Khusrau to use the financial resources of the province of Orissa, and appointed the powerful Raja Man Singh as his ataliq. Salim's younger son, Khurram, who had been brought up by Ruqaiya Begum and the Padshah, only ever referred to his father as 'Shah Bhai', or older brother, thereby introducing a worrying degree of equality in their dynamic. Another grandson, Mirza Rustam, the son of Murad, was said to listen to the council of neither father nor mother, so ruled was he by his grandfather. Indeed, the Padshah declared in open court that he 'loved grandchildren more than sons'. These developments were a direct challenge to Salim and his brothers, demonstrating to the heir apparent and to the royal mirzas that there were other potential candidates to the Mughal throne.

The 1590s had proved to be a decade of consolidation for the Mughal Empire. In his fifties, Akbar was at the peak of his powers. After a decade in Lahore, Kashmir had been incorporated into the empire and the north-west frontier had been secured through the conquest of Sind and would cause no further trouble for the rest of the Padshah's reign. Similarly, the eastern frontier had been stabilized largely through the heroic efforts of Raja Man Singh. With Bihar secured to the empire, Raja Man Singh had turned to the neighbouring state of Orissa in 1590. Orissa had been ruled by an Afghan family of the Lohani tribe but Raja Man Singh was able to force Nasir Khan Afghan into submission and 150 elephants were part of the large tribute offered by the Afghans when they accepted Mughal supremacy. They also ceded the temple of Lord Jagannath at Puri, a powerful symbol of the Orissa rulers. The Afghans would offer some further resistance but would be conclusively beaten by Raja Man Singh in 1592. The last of the rebellions in Gujarat had been crushed as well. Now with a huge contingent of 1,823 mansabdars, with the capacity to raise 141,000 cavalrymen, the Padshah looked southwards to that most alluring of places—the Deccan.

In 1527, the Bahmani sultanate had fragmented into the five Deccani sultanates of Ahmadnagar, Berar, Bijapur, Bidar, and Golconda, making the region a great deal more politically volatile, as Persian Shias jousted with Afghan Sunnis and local shaikhzadas for dominance. In addition, there was Khandesh, with its capital at Burhanpur, a prickly buffer between the northern territories and the Deccan. When succession struggles began in Ahmadnagar in 1588, a younger sibling, Burhan Shah, fled to the Mughal court for assistance. Burhan Shah successfully claimed the Ahmadnagar